Participant information sheets

Letter for potential participants – Athletes who have left school and over 18 years, athletes still at school aged 15-18 years, parents and teachers.
Ethics Approval Number: HREC: S/11/347

Dear _____,
After being confirmed in my candidature for the award of PhD, I am about to commence the research stage of a project entitled **'High Performance athletes at school: A study of conflicting demands.'** The chief investigator is Ms Maureen O'Neill and I am being supervised in this work by Dr Bill Allen and Ms Angela Calder, both lecturers at the University of the Sunshine Coast.

There are two major, related aims of the project. The first is to find out what needs and problems the high performance school-age athletes themselves identify when they combine high level sport and academic endeavours. The second is to examine and propose some models of schooling in Australia that may best support the high performance athlete who is still at school. This research seeks to explore the competing demands on young people who are both high performance athletes yet still at school.

As part of the project I am proposing to conduct interviews of approximately 45 minutes to one hour's length with the relevant participant groups of: athletes who have left school and over 18 years who were high performance athletes whilst at school, young athletes still at school who are all aged 15-18 years old and who are high performance athletes and currently still at school, parents who have high performance school-age athletes and school officials such as teachers who have experience with high performance school-age athletes. Questions asked during the interview will focus on the perspectives of high performance school-age athletes' experiences of the needs and problems in attempting to combine both sport and education at the same time. Further, questions about what are the characteristics of successful schooling models that best meet the needs of these young people will be explored. Responses will be based on the following research guiding questions:

- What are the goals and expected outcomes that high performance school-age athletes have, and how might these different goals be in conflict?
- What schooling models exist in Australia for high performance school-age athletes?
- What are the experiences of the high performance athlete at school within different schooling models?
- How do high performance athletes (who have left school) identify the strengths and weaknesses of the school model they were in?

I am asking you to participate in this research project by agreeing to take part in an interview at a site of your choice, and at a time convenient to you. I will contact you shortly by telephone or by e-mail to ask if you are willing to participate further and, if so, to find out where and when you may want to be interviewed. There is absolutely no problem if you choose not to participate from the outset, or if you decide to withdraw from the project at any time later.
If you have any further questions regarding the research design or methods, please contact Dr. Bill Allen (07 5430 1282).

Thank you for your assistance,
Ms. Maureen O'Neill
PhD Candidate
University of the Sunshine Coast